CHAPTER 6

(Just Enough) Algebraic Geometry

"whatever doesn't kill you simply makes you stranger"
— Joker

"I am sad to hear that one cannot present Weil's results without juggling with generic points; as a matter of fact, the unbridled abuse of generic points necessarily hides the few situations in which their use is truly essential, such as the proof that every endomorphism of the Jacobian comes from a correspondence. As Chevalley says, one feels frustrated when faced with a proof like that one."
— Grothendieck to Serre in a letter on November 22, 1956

6.1. There are two routes to algebraic geometry. The first one goes through the theory of varieties and the second one, which is relatively modern, goes directly through the theory of schemes. In this book, we will discuss about the latter mostly. However, historically speaking, varieties have been crucial for algebraic geometry too and, of course, play a significant role in many parts of mathematics (and physics!). So in the initial parts of this chapter, we will discuss the classical theory of varieties.

6.2. Scheme has been standard for more than over six decades. Before the language of schemes, there was the definition of algebraic variety in the pens of Weil [**24**] and Zariski (and the abstract variety in the sense of Serre). Affine variety is just a special case of the schemes. The formalization of scheme theory was done by Grothendieck (with the help of works by Serre, Chevalley) in Éléments de Géométrie Algébrique.

In this chapter, we will discuss some basics of varieties that will comfort one who has not seen them so far. We will swiftly change our discussion to schemes. This will be an important chapter in Prelude to Schemes as we will discuss most of EGA work herein.

Textbooks [**25**, **26**] do a nice job to introduce varieties and [**22**] is an excellent resource algebraic geometry in the languages of schemes straightway, and this will be closer to our hearts in this chapter. For the part about varieties, we will follow [**25**].

This is a part of Prelude of Schemes project available at `https://aayushayh.github.io/PtoS.html`.
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6.3. Throughout the chapter, we fix k to be an algebraically closed field unless stated otherwise.

1. A little bit of Variety does not kill you

Definition 6.4 (Affine space over k). An affine n-space over k, denoted as A_k^n, is a set of all n-tuples of elements of k. An element P of A_k^n is called point and the components of $P \in A_k^n$ are called coordinates of point P. So if $P = (a_1, \cdots, a_n)$ with $a_i \in k$, then we call a_i to be coordinates.

In a very loose sense, A_k^n is just an arbitrary geometric way to write k^n (without an origin). But we will postpone this discuss to a later stage.

6.5. Given a polynomial ring[1] over k, $A = k[x_1, \cdots, x_n]$, we can write elements of A as elements $f \in A$ which is a function $f : A_k^n \to k^n$,

$$f(P) = f(a_1, \cdots, a_n), \quad f \in A \text{ and } P \in A_k^n \tag{114}$$

and we can define the zeroes of f as a set $Z(f)$ but say we have a subset $T \subseteq A$, so define the zero set of T as the common zeroes of all the elements of T

$$Z(T) = \{P \in A_k^n | \forall f \in T, f(P) = 0\} \tag{115}$$

6.6. We will now denote affine $n-$space A_k^n by $\mathbf{A}^n$.

Definition 6.7 (Algebraic Sets). A subset V of $\mathbf{A}^n$ is called *algebraic set* if $V = Z(T)$ for some T.

Definition 6.8. An *algebraic plane curve* over k is an algebraic set $C \subseteq \mathbf{A}^2$. We will hopefully discuss affine curves in detail in detail.

6.9. We will define the Zariski topology on $\mathbf{A}^n$. Now, the intersection of two algebraic sets is an algebraic set and so is the union of two algebraic sets. (See [**25**] for a proof.)

The Zariski topology on $\mathbf{A}^n$ is defined by taking the complements of algebraic sets to be open subsets. Since their intersections and unions will be open, it is a topology. And the empty set and whole space being algebraic sets, are both open.

6.10. A non-empty subset W of a topological space X is said to be irreducible if it cannot be written as the union of two proper subsets of X and closed in Y, i.e.,

$$W = W_1 \cup W_2. \tag{116}$$

(A curve is said to be irreducible if its polynomial equation is irreducible.)

Proposition 6.11. Any closed set is a finite union of irreducible closed sets. The product of any two irreducible closed sets is irreducible again.

[1] A polynomial ring is a unique factorization domain (UFD).

Definition 6.12 (Affine Algebraic Variety). We define an *affine algebraic variety* as an irreducible closed subset of $\mathbf{A}^n$. Moreover, if we take an open subset of an affine variety[2], then it is called a *quasi-affine variety.*

6.13. Now, the subsets of $\mathbf{A}^n$ can be mapped to ideals in A. Given any subset $V \subseteq \mathbf{A}^n$, we define

$$I(V) = \{f \in A = k[x_1, \cdots, x_n] | f(P) = 0 \ \forall P \in V\} \tag{117}$$

Theorem 6.14 (Hilbert's Weak Nullstellansatz, from [**22**]). Let $A = k[x_1, \cdots, x_n]$ be a polynomial ring and k be an algebraically closed field (see 6.16 for why), then the maximal ideals in A are precisely those ideals of the form $(x_1 - a_1, \cdots, x_n - a_n)$, where $a_i \in k$.

6.15. The statement of theorem 6.14 might not be the best way to introduce Hilbert's Nullstellansatz in a progression of varieties. But a statement exists about the correspondence between ideals and varieties.

Note that in Point. 6.5, we defined the zero set of a subset of $A = k[x_1, \cdots, x_n]$. Given an ideal $J \subseteq A$, we can define a zero set, let us call it *zero locus* J and re-notate it by

$$V(J) = \{P \in \mathbf{A}^n | \forall f \in J \ f(P) = 0\} \tag{118}$$

and when $V(J) = \varnothing$ that means that there are no points in $\mathbf{A}^n$ where polynomials in J vanish simultaneously.

6.16. There could be two situations when $V(J) = \emptyset$. Firstly, when $J = A$, then $1 \in J$ and for any point $P \in \mathbf{A}^n$, we have $1(P) \neq 0$. Therefore $V(J) = \varnothing$ and hence no point lies in $V(J)$. One can deduce that the question of if $V(J) =$ becomes non-trivial only if J is a proper ideal in A. Second instance when $V(J) = \varnothing$ happens when k is not algebraically closed, for examples $\mathbb{Q}, \mathbb{R}$. Given $k = \mathbb{R}$ or $k = \mathbb{Q}$ and an ideal $J = (x^2+1) \subseteq \mathbb{R}[x]$ generated by x^2+1, the zero-locus is empty $V(J) = \varnothing$. Hence, one is required to have an algebraically closed field k.

- It is also worth noting that for $J = 0$, we have $V(J) = \mathbf{A}^n$.
- If $I \subset J$, then $V(I) \supset V(J)$ which is known as inclusion-reversing.
- Since the union and intersection of algebraic sets is algebraic set (see 6.9) and any algebraic set is equal to $V(J)$ for some ideal J, we have $V(I) \cup V(J) = V(I \cap J)$ and for any collection of ideals $\{J_\alpha\}$, the intersection $\bigcap_\alpha V(J_\alpha) = V(\sum_\alpha J_\alpha)$.

Now, before moving ahead, some important points.

Proposition 6.17 (See [**27**]). If A and B are integral domains with every element of B integral over A (in other words, B is integral over A), then A is a field iff B is a field.

[2]In french, the word 'variété' means both an algebraic variety and differentiable manifold.

LEMMA 6.18 (Noether's Normalization, [2]). Let k be an algebraically closed field and $A = k[x_1, \cdots, x_n]$ a finitely generated k-algebra.[3] There exists some $m \leq n$, for which there exist elements $y_1, y_2, \cdots, y_m$ algebraically independent over k such that A is a finitely generated module over the k-subalgebra $k[y_1, y_2, \cdots, y_m]$.

LEMMA 6.19 (Zariski's Lemma). Let $k \to L$ be an extension of fields such that L is of finite type over k, then L is finite over k

THEOREM 6.20 (Hilbert's Weak Nullstellensatz (again), [28]). For any algebraically closed field k, for any proper ideal $J \subsetneq k[x_1, \cdots, x_n]$ we have $V(J) \neq \varnothing$.

PROOF. For the ideal J is proper in $A = k[x_1, \cdots, x_n]$, it would be contained in a maximal ideal $\mathfrak{m} \subseteq A$ (by Zorn's Lemma) and $V(\mathfrak{m}) \subseteq V(J)$ by inclusion-reversing 6.16. So just show that $V(\mathfrak{m}) \neq \varnothing$. Let us look at the quotient $L = A/\mathfrak{m}$ and since $\mathfrak{m}$ is maximal ideal, L is a field and L is a finitely generated k-algebra. We can take k to be a sub-field of L by a natural homomorphism $k \hookrightarrow L$. Since k is an algebraically closed field, k does not have any non-trivial finite field extensions, by Lemma. 6.19, we have $k \cong L$.

The quotient map (which is a projection) $\pi : A \to L = A/\mathfrak{m}$ is $x_i \mapsto a_i \in k$. The kernel of this quotient map is just $ker(\pi) = \mathfrak{m}$. Let us pick $f \in J \subseteq \mathfrak{m}$, then we have

$$f(a_1, \cdots, a_n) = f(\pi(x_1), \cdots, \pi(x_n)) = \pi(f) = 0 \tag{119}$$

and hence $P = \{a_1, \cdots, a_n\} \in \mathbf{A}^n$ lies in $V(J)$.

REMARK 6.21. The statements in 6.14 and 6.20 are actually the same. If not obvious, we will see it later.

PROPOSITION 6.22. An algebraic set is irreducible if and only if its ideal (as defined in 6.13) is a prime ideal.

PROOF. To show this, using above discussions, we also know that there exists a one-to-one inclusion-reversing correspondence between algebraic sets and ideals (via Nullstellensatz) by $Y \mapsto I(Y)$ and $\mathfrak{a} \mapsto Z(\mathfrak{a})$ where $I(Y)$ is the ideal of an algebraic set and $Z(\mathfrak{a})$ is the algebraic set of a (radical) ideal $\mathfrak{a}$.

To prove this (from one side), one has to show that $I(V)$ is a prime ideal. We follow [25]. Let $fg \in I(V)$, then using inclusion-reversing property, $V \subseteq Z(fg) = Z(f) \cup Z(g)$. We can write it as $V = (V \cap Z(f)) \cup (Y \cap Z(g))$ but since V is irreducible algebraic set, we have either $V = (V \cap Z(f))$ which means $V \subseteq Z(f)$ or $V = (V \cap Z(g))$ which means $V \subseteq Z(g)$, which means that either $f \in I(V)$ or $g \in I(V)$ and hence, $I(V)$ is a prime ideal.

[3]Here, we gave the statement for a polynomial ring as finitely generated k-algebra but Noether's normalization works for any finitely generated k-algebra.

Now, the other side. Let us say that $\mathfrak{p}$ is a prime ideal and say $Z(\mathfrak{p}) = V_1 \cup V_2$, then $\mathfrak{p} = I(V_1) \cap I(V_2)$, so we have either $\mathfrak{p} = I(V_1)$ or $\mathfrak{p} = I(V_2)$ and hence, we have either $Z(\mathfrak{p}) = V_1$ or $Z(\mathfrak{p}) = V_2$ and so $Z(\mathfrak{p})$ is irreducible.

Definition 6.23. For an algebraic set $V \subset \mathbf{A}^n$, we define the affine coordinate ring $A(V) = A/I(V)$.

Remark 6.24. This affine coordinate ring is an integral domain if and only if V is irreducible.

Now, we can move to some important topology of the varieties.

Definition 6.25 (Noetherian Topological Space). For a topological space X, if it satisfies a descending chain condition for closed subsets of X

$$V_1 \supseteq V_2 \supseteq V_3 \cdots \tag{120}$$

such that there exists an integer r with $V_r = V_{r+1} = \cdots$ then such a topological space is called *Noetherian*.

Example 6.26. The affine space $\mathbf{A}^n$ is Noetherian. Since, $A = k[x_1, \cdots, x_n]$ is a Noetherian ring, the chain of ideals in A saturates and from Nullstellensatz, we have $V_i = Z(I(V_i))$ and $I(V_i)$ is stationary in A then chain of V_i will also be stationery.

Definition 6.27. A topological space X is called *locally Noetherian* if every point has a neighborhood which is Noetherian.

Remark 6.28 (Stacks [**11**], Lemma 04MF). If X is a locally Noetherian topological space, then X is locally connected.

Lemma 6.29 (Stacks [**11**], Lemma 0052). Let X be a Noetherian topological space, then

- Any subset of X with induced topology is Noetherian.
- Topological space X has finitely many irreducible components.
- Each irreducible component of X contains a nonempty open of X.

Lemma 6.30 (Stacks [**11**], Lemma 04Z8). Let $f : X \to Y$ be a continuous map of topological spaces, then

- If X is Noetherian, then so is $f(X)$.
- If X is locally Noetherian and f is open map, then $f(X)$ is locally Noetherian.

Proposition 6.31. Now, every algebraic set in $\mathbf{A}^n$ can be written uniquely as a union of varieties, where no two two contain each other.

The discussions above make it clear.

Definition 6.32 (Krull dimension of X). Let X be a topological space. A chain of irreducible closed subsets of X is a sequence $Z_0 \subset Z_1 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n$ with each Z_i irreducible and $Z_i \neq Z_{i+1}$. Then n is the *length* of the chain. We define the Krull dimension of X as

$$dim(X) = \sup\{\text{lengths of chains of irreducible closed subsets}\} \tag{121}$$

Dimension can be infinite. One can define for empty set $\varnothing$, its dimension as $dim(\varnothing) = -\infty$ as there are no chains of irreducible closed subsets at all for $\varnothing$.

Definition 6.33 (As [25]). We define the *dimension* of (quasi)-affine variety as its dimension as a topological space.

Example 6.34. The dimension of $\mathbf{A}^1$ is 1 as the maximal length chains are like $\{P\} \subset \mathbf{A}^1$. In fact, the dimension of $\mathbf{A}^n$ is n as there exist a chain of length n

$$V(x_1, \cdots, x_n) \subset V(x_1, \cdots, x_{n-1}) \subset \cdots \subset V(x_1) \subset \mathbf{A}^n \tag{122}$$

Definition 6.35 (Height of prime ideals). Let R be a ring, then for chain of length n of (distinct) prime ideals $\mathfrak{p}_0 \subset \mathfrak{p}_1 \subset \cdots \subset \mathfrak{p}_n = \mathfrak{p}$ such that $\mathfrak{p}_i \neq \mathfrak{p}_{i+1}$ for $i = 0, \cdots, n-1$, we define the *height* of $\mathfrak{p}$ to be the supremum of all the integers n.

Definition 6.36 (Krull dimension of a ring). We define the *Krull dimension* of ring A to be supremum of the heights (see Def. 6.35) of all prime ideals.

Definition 6.37. Given a prime ideal $\mathfrak{p}$ in R, the dimension of the local ring $R_{\mathfrak{p}}$ is the height of $\mathfrak{p}$.

Proposition 6.38. If $V \subseteq \mathbf{A}^n$ is an affine algebraic set, then the dimension of V is the dimension of its affine coordinate ring $A(V)$ (see Def. 6.23)

$$\dim V = \dim A(V) \tag{123}$$

Proof. Krull dimension of V is defined using Def. 6.33, so it is the supremum of lengths of chains of irreducible closed subsets

$$Z_0 \subset Z_1 \subset \cdots Z_n \subset V \tag{124}$$

which under Nullstellensatz follows a reversing-inclusion bijection with the prime ideals of the coordinate ring $A(V)$ (see 6.22), so $Z_i \mapsto I(Z_i)$ which are prime ideals and reverses the inclusion, so

$$\mathfrak{p}_n \subset \mathfrak{p}_{n-1} \subset \cdots \subset \mathfrak{p}_1 \subset \mathfrak{p}_0 \tag{125}$$

is a chain of prime ideals in ring $A = k[x_1, \cdots, x_n]$. All of the primes contain $I(V)$, hence a chain

$$\mathfrak{p}_n/I(V) \subset \mathfrak{p}_{n-1}/I(V) \subset \cdots \subset \mathfrak{p}_1/I(V) \subset \mathfrak{p}_0/I(V) \tag{126}$$

which is a chain of prime ideals in $A(V)$ which is the affine coordinate ring.

Thus the chains of irreducible closed subsets of V and chains of prime ideals in its affine coordinate ring $A(V)$ are in bijection, so the lengths of corresponding chains are equal. Therefore, the supremum in both definitions of 6.32 and 6.36 are equal, hence *up to reversal of order*

$$\dim V = \dim A(V) \tag{127}$$

Conversely, for a chain a prime ideals in $A(V)$

$$\mathfrak{p}_0 \subset \mathfrak{p}_1 \subset \cdots \subset \mathfrak{p}_n \tag{128}$$

when taken inverse images in A and then its zero loci in V, one gets a chain of irreducible closed subset of V with same length.

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